

Pedro Magaña Sáenz

Agricultural and Applied Economics, University of Wisconsin-Madison

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Education

University of Wisconsin—Madison | Wisconsin, United States

Ph.D. in Agricultural and Applied Economics

May 2026 (expected)

M.S. in Agricultural and Applied Economics

2022

University of Michigan—Ann Arbor | Michigan, United States

M.S. in Applied Economics

2019

M.A. in Public Policy

2019

Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM) | Mexico City, Mexico

B.A. in Economics

2012

Fields of Interest

Development Economics; Agricultural Economics; Public Economics; Public Policy

Working papers

Signed, Sealed, Delivered: Digital Receipts in the Ugandan Dairy Chain (Job Market Paper)

with David J. Henning

We provide causal evidence that digital receipts—SMS messages reporting milk deliveries—can improve accountability, delivery behavior, and product quality in agricultural markets. In a randomized experiment with dairy cooperatives in western Uganda, we find that treated farmers, particularly those who self-deliver, are significantly more likely to deliver milk. This increase in delivery activity occurs without a change in average volumes delivered, suggesting a shift along the extensive margin. The intervention also improves milk quality: treated farmers deliver higher-quality (less diluted) milk, as measured by lactometer readings. Among farmers who rely on transporters, digital receipts increase the likelihood of detecting discrepancies, switching baseline transporters, and reporting lower trust in intermediaries. These results show that the intervention works differently depending on whether information frictions are present: for self-deliverers, who already have full observability over their deliveries, impacts are concentrated on participation, while for transporter users, where observability is limited, impacts are concentrated on detecting discrepancies and moving away from dishonest transporters. By turning unobservable transactions into verifiable digital records, SMS receipts enhance transparency and make intermediary behavior more observable. Overall, our findings show how simple digital tools can reduce information frictions, shift farmer and intermediary behavior, and improve product quality in fragmented agricultural systems.

Banking Amidst Conflict: How Violence Shapes Financial Inclusion in Mexico

with Xiaofei Wang

We investigate how conflict influences the use of formal financial services in Mexico. Using police reports and death records from the Ministry of Health, we construct municipality-level forecasts of expected violence from 2011 to 2020. Deviations from these forecasts—months with unexpectedly high violence—serve as proxies for unanticipated public safety shocks. We then study how these localized, time-specific episodes affect individuals' use of financial services, distinguishing between traditional and non-traditional banking channels. Our analysis leverages administrative transaction data from the National Banking and Securities Commission, covering all municipalities in Mexico over the same time period. We also examine whether security concerns accelerate the adoption of digital financial tools as a risk mitigation strategy. By focusing on behavioral responses to violence, we provide insights on the indirect transaction costs of insecurity and the adaptive strategies households use to navigate high-risk environments. This research

contributes to the growing literature on financial inclusion in conflict-affected settings and offers policy-relevant insights for building more resilient financial systems in the face of localized violence.

Work in progress

Aligning Incentives through Digital Monitoring: Evidence from the Ugandan Dairy Sector
From Prayer to Progress: Religious Festivals and Development in Mexico

Research Experience

Research Assistant, University of Wisconsin | Madison, Wisconsin
Professors: Dr. Dustin Frye, Dr. Corbett Grainger, and Dr. Bradford Barham 2021 – Present

Research Assistant, University of Michigan | Ann Arbor, Michigan
Professors: Dr. Eduardo Montero and Dr. Zach Y. Brown Spring 2020

Research Assistant, Center on Finance, Law and Policy, University of Michigan | Ann Arbor, Michigan
Professors: Michael Barr, J.D.; Dr. Antoinette Schoar, and Dr. Eldar Shafir Fall 2019

Research Assistant, Northwestern University | Chicago, Illinois
Professors: Dr. Erika Deserranno and Dr. Gianmarco Leon-Ciliotta Summer 2019

Research Associate, University of Michigan | Ann Arbor, Michigan
Economic Growth Institute 2018 – 2019

Research Assistant, University of Michigan | Ann Arbor, Michigan
Professors: Dr. Dean Yang; Dr. Xavier Giné, and Dr. Jessica Goldberg 2017 – 2018

Country Office Intern, Innovations for Poverty Action | Lilongwe, Malawi
Professors: Dr. Dean Yang; Dr. Xavier Giné, and Dr. Jessica Goldberg Summer 2017

Research Coordinator, Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM) | Mexico City, Mexico
Professors: Dr. Enrique Seira and Dr. Joyce Sadka 2011 – 2012

Professional Experience

Economic Analysis Coordinator, Ministry of Finance | Mexico City, Mexico
Developed and monitored venture capital investments in agribusiness 2014 – 2016

Market Analyst, Laureate International Universities | Mexico City, Mexico
Developed statistical models to assess the impact of price changes on consumer behavior 2013 – 2014

Financial Analyst, Laureate International Universities | Mexico City, Mexico
Led analytical reporting on fixed asset budgets and forecasts for the CFO 2012 – 2013

Parliamentary Advisor, Senate of Mexico | Mexico City, Mexico
Advised senator on the economic viability of proposed legislation 2010 – 2011

Research Grants

The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics – University of Chicago, \$15,000 USD 2025
Role: PI – with David J. Henning and Erick Molina Perez

International Growth Centre (IGC) – Agri-SME Evidence Fund, £20,000 GBP 2024
Role: PI – with David J. Henning

The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics – University of Chicago, \$15,000 USD <i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>	2023
J-PAL/CEGA – Digital Agricultural Innovations and Services (DAISI) Initiative , \$71,000 USD <i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>	2023
International Growth Centre (IGC) – Small Project Facility, £20,000 GBP <i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>	2022

Total external funding raised as PI: \$151,000 USD

Honors and Awards

AAEA Travel Grant – Agricultural & Applied Economics Association (AAEA)	2025
Thomsen Distinguished Graduate Dissertator Fellowship (nominated) – University of Wisconsin—Madison	2024
AAE Dissertator Research Award – University of Wisconsin—Madison, \$1,000 USD	2024
Barbara and Thomas Lyon Scholarship, \$4,000 USD, University of Wisconsin—Madison.	2023
UW-Madison Travel Grant, \$1,500 USD, University of Wisconsin—Madison	2022
Outstanding Teaching Assistant Award, University of Wisconsin—Madison	2021 – 2022
Rackham International Student Fellowship, \$10,000 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor.	2019
Annenberg Internship, \$7,500 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor	2017
Ford School Fellowship, \$2,500 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor	2017

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, University of Wisconsin Madison, Wisconsin <i>AAE 474/ECON 474: Economic Problems of Developing Areas</i> <i>AAE 350: World Hunger and Malnutrition</i> <i>MATH 221: Calculus and Analytic Geometry II</i>	<i>Fall 2025</i> <i>Spring 2022</i> <i>Fall 2020</i>
Teaching Assistant, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan <i>PUBPOL 639: Quantitative Methods for Program Evaluation</i> <i>POLSCI 369: International Economic Relations</i> <i>PUBPOL 639: Quantitative Methods for Program Evaluation</i> <i>POLSCI 490: Game Theory and Formal Models</i>	<i>Spring 2019</i> <i>Fall 2018</i> <i>Spring 2018</i> <i>Fall 2017</i>

Pre-Doctoral Publications

Magaña Sáenz, P.F. (2015). Behavioral Economics and Nudges Applied to Pawnshops. **Gaceta de Economía**, 34, 96-126. (Original in Spanish)

Talks

2025	AFE 2025 (University of Chicago), AAEA/WAEA Joint Annual Meeting, Juli Plant Grainger Public Workshop, Applied Economics Workshop (University of Wisconsin)
2024	Development Workshop, Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)
2023	Development Workshop, Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)
2022	Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)
2021	Development Lab (University of Wisconsin)

Affiliations

Graduate Research Fellow, Institute for Research on Poverty

2025 – 2026

Other Information

Languages: Spanish (Native), English (Fluent)

Skills: Stata (Advanced), L^AT_EX(Advanced), Microsoft Office (Advanced), R (Intermediate), Python (Intermediate)

References

Laura Schechter
Vilas Distinguished Achievement Professor
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1180 Observatory Drive
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